Case Study : UPI / Online Payment Fraud (The "Digital Arrest" & AI Voice Scam, 2024)

- **What the crime is**: This involves the misuse of India's Unified Payments Interface (UPI) to steal money. A modern version includes "Digital Arrest," where scammers use intimidation and AI voice cloning to force immediate transfers.

- **How it typically happens:**
  1. The Hook: The victim gets a WhatsApp video call from someone pretending to be a high-ranking police or CBI official. The background often resembles a real police station.
  2. The Fear Factor: The scammer tells the victim their Aadhaar ID was found in a package with illegal drugs or that a relative is in custody for a crime.
  3. The AI Twist: In 2024 cases (like the attempt on Sunil Mittal's executive), scammers used AI voice cloning to imitate a trusted authority or boss, confirming the "emergency" over a separate call.
  4. The Transfer: Under the pretense of a "security deposit" to avoid immediate arrest, the victim is pressured into transferring large amounts via UPI or RTGS to "government-verified" (but actually fake) accounts.

- **Who is usually targeted**: Middle-aged professionals, senior citizens, and corporate executives who can be pressured by legal threats or authoritative voices.

- **Consequences:**
  - Financial Loss: In late 2024, the Chairman of Vardhman Group, S.P. Oswal, was defrauded of ₹7 crore using this method.

  - Psychological Trauma: Victims experience severe stress from being kept under "virtual surveillance" for hours or days.

- **Source:** The Hindu / India Today Cyber Reports (October–December 2024).